The Wings She Carried

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/31210583.

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Teen And Up Audiences

Archive Warning:
No Archive Warnings Apply

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F/F, F/M

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She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

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Post-Canon, Post-War, Post-war Ennui, Scorpia is a Good Friend (She-Ra), Lesbian Disaster Adora (She-Ra), Catra (She-Ra) Needs a Hug, Minor Perfuma/Scorpia (She-Ra), Wingwoman Scorpia (She-Ra), Fluff and Hurt/Comfort, POV Scorpia (She-Ra)

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by 4theHonourofGräysküll (AVAwolfpack), But_Its_For_Science (DakianDelomast), DakianDelomast

Summary

"Yeah, I know." I let out a sigh and lean a little harder on my forearms. On the garden tiers below us, a group of children play tag between the towers of the topiary. Not a care in the world to disturb their rambunctiousness. "I always try to be happy outside even when I don't feel it inside. Every morning, I'd wake up and breathe in a new day and push down doubts and insecurities. It can be… exhausting honestly."

Adora studies me, the golden object in her hand momentarily forgotten, a deep furrow to her brow. The expression sends a wave of doubt through me and I immediately backpedal.

"What? Did I say something weird? Jeez, I'm sorry. I do that sometimes."

"No… just…" She shakes her head slowly and drops her eyes to hands again. "Waking up happy. I've never really tried to do that before. There were a lot of mornings when I could have used that. I wonder…" Her words falter and she clutches the curio tightly in a fist before letting out a long breath. She looks like a woman who has arisen from a fight, scarred but victorious. Burdened beneath an unshakable weariness.

She needs some cheering up. Good thing Scorpia is on the job.

Notes

Hello everyone!

Welcome to the next chapter of Scorpia's story where she finds an Adora with a lot on her mind. She's been on a good streak of helping her friends with Catra and Entrapta. Hopefully she can do the same for Adora.

We'll be dropping some big things in honor of the one year anniversary of the season 5 premiere (May 15th). So be watching for that!

See the end of the work for more notes

It’s another bright and pleasant afternoon in Bright Moon as I make my way down the edificial halls. The typical trill of birdsong and music that adorned the halls is drowned out by hammers and chisels working away at the stonework. The masons are busy filling in the cracks and divots scarring the castle from the war and the explosive florification with a mixture of stonedust and magic. An ancient technique in Etheria that didn’t remove cracks, but instead filled them in with beautiful iridescence. Like thin strands of starlight set into stone.

“Lookin’ good!” I say as I pass by the masons. “Keep it up!”

Some pause to wave at me, but most of them are too focused, too dedicated. Everyone wants to heal Etheria in their own way after the war. For some, that means sealing in cracks in the infrastructure. For She-Ra, it meant zapping everything with plants. As Perfuma always says: the universe has a way of healing itself.

I come to the war room—the *planning* room, I mean. There’s no need for a war room anymore, but there is certainly a lot of relief efforts and reconstruction projects to plan. It’s a much more fitting name. I peek my head inside and see Queen Glimmer standing over the holographic display with Bow at her right hand and General Juliet at her left. The general clutches her helmet beneath an arm while she points at parts of the hologram with the other. She hasn’t had much occasion to wear her helmet recently.

“The reports from Erelandia say the relief mission was a success. The plants have been cleared and the citizens have been able to resume normal activity. On top of that, harvests are looking good for this year.”

“Great!” Glimmer says. “Any word back from Frosta yet?”

“Not yet, Your Majesty.”

“We should move focus to opening up the mountain passes to Dryl then.” Bow zooms in on the mountains leading to Dryl.

Geometric triangles represent the spires of the castle against the sloping ridges. "With Entrapta busy prepping Darla, they'll need our help."

Glimmer lets out a long breath before gathering herself again. "That's a good idea Bow. General, send the orders."

"Right away, Your Majesty." General Juliet salutes and starts for the door. She draws up short when she notices me standing at the doorway. An old reflex, I'm sure, but her hand goes to where she usually wears a sword before she regains herself. "Excuse me, Princess."

I wave a pincer and smile. "Hey guys. Sorry. Didn't mean to disturb you there."

"Scorpia!" Bow's brief look of surprise quickly turns into a smile. "We didn't notice you."

Glimmer waves the general on before smiling at me as well. I can't help but notice the fatigue dimming her usually bright eyes. "How long have you been standing there?"

I hedge a little farther into the room. "Oh. Not long. I've just been on a walk, thought I'd pop in."

"That sounds wonderful." Glimmer turns her gaze forlornly back to the holographic display. "I've been stuck in here *all* day."

"Been working hard, huh?" I put my pincers on my hips and examine the display. There are several red pins scattered across the kingdoms, marking areas still paralyzed by the explosive florification or the lasting effects of Horde Prime's invasion. "Oh wow! Look at all that progress. Last time I was in here there was a lot more red."

"We're getting it done. Slowly but surely." Glimmer exhales wearily and sets her hands on the table. "Etheria will be back to normal soon."

"Well, what even *is* normal, you know?"

Bow and Glimmer glance up at me in confusion, sending a short jolt of panic through me.

I rub a pincer behind my neck. "I just mean with the magic released and the Horde gone and the wars over, Etheria is different from how it's been for a long time. Like, do we even know what a normal Etheria is supposed to look like?"

Bow taps his chin in thought. "That's a good point. So much has changed even since Mara's time. Maybe I should ask my dads for what Etheria was historically like. They might have something in that library…" He takes out his tracker pad and quickly types out something on it.

Glimmer groans and finally collapses into the seat behind her, slumping over the hologram so her forehead hit the table. "Great. Even after everything…" She let out a groan like when someone picks up something too heavy for them before I can help them out. "I just wanted things to go back to how they should be."

"Well, I don't think it's a bad thing it's all changed!" I gesture over my shoulder, where the halls echo with the sound of masonwork. "I love what they're doing out there—with that sparkly stone paste thing? It's beautiful! It's different from how the halls looked before, but I think it looks better."

Glimmer tilted her head in thought, her eyes on the doorway. A wistful smile came across her face. "My mom always said the same thing. I haven't really looked at the progress around Bright Moon yet, but maybe I'll take a break and walk around."

"That's what I've been doing and, lemme tell ya, it's pretty great. You have a beautiful kingdom."

Bow grins warmly at Glimmer and sets a hand on her shoulder. She straightens and smiles. "Thanks, Scorpia."

I feel rather proud of myself. It's not every day you get to cheer up a queen. "No problem! It's like Perfuma always says—don't dwell on the negative. Look at the positive. Oh! Speaking of, have you guys seen Perfuma around? We had some plans but I can't seem to find her anywhere."

Glimmer shakes her head but Bow says, "I think she's with Catra. Something about unlocking her… chalk art?"

Glimmer raises an eyebrow. "Chakras?"

He snaps his fingers and points at me. "Yup! That's it. Whatever *that* is."

"Oh good! You know, now that you mention it, I remember her saying something about helping Catra today." I chuckle and shrug. "Silly me. Guess I forgot."

"Bow, I don't think I can stare at this hologram a second longer." Glimmer stands and laces her arm through his. "Let's take that break."

"Okay." He smiles at her before turning back to me and saying, "I think they're out on the garden balco—" They disappear with a flash of sparkles before he can finish the sentence.

I stand for a moment glancing around the planning room, wondering if I'm supposed to secure it before I leave. But the thought is silly. Something left over from the war. So I shrug and walk out, continuing down the halls amid the symphony of the masons working and the warmth of the sunlight.

I arrive at the garden balcony. Though the worst of the florification has been cleared away at this point, the topiary is still overgrown and towering, overtaking much of the normally open and clear garden. The sun is starting to set, painting the horizon a deep red, fading to a soft pink at the farthest reaches of the sky. It casts streaks of pearlescent light like a painter took a giant brush and stroked it from horizon to horizon. A wandering flock of

birds floats on a estival breeze among the glowing motes of magic within the air.

Perfuma and Catra are nowhere in sight out here. Well jeez, I'm really running out of places to look for them. Maybe it was time to call it and just wait in our room for whenever Perfuma was done. But then I notice her.

Standing at the topmost tier of the balcony with her back to me, overlooking the lower tiers of the garden down into the sparkling river valley, is Adora. She is hard to miss in her usual red jacket, with her blonde hair pulled back in her ponytail. The hair poof seems extra poofy against the setting sunlight. She leans her elbows against the railing, one boot crossed behind the ankle of the other. Her head is tilted downward as she studies something in her hand rather than the beauty of the scenery around her.

The sight is almost startling. I haven't seen Adora alone since the war ended. She's always off with Glimmer or Bow or Catra, providing the services of She-Ra whenever and however she could. Always running around doing something. That's just Adora. Even during the war, I hadn't ever seen her stand so still.

Maybe she knows where Perfuma and Catra are. It seems rude to ask right now. Whatever she's doing, she looks like she's concentrating super hard, but it couldn't hurt to ask, right? I come up behind her and pause. I hate this part. She's distracted, and I can't draw her attention without startling her.

Maybe if I'm extra soft…

I clear my throat. "Hey, Adora…?"

She jumps upward like a shock of my Red Garnet lightning just zapped up her legs. The small bauble she holds scatters up into the air. She panics, reaching up wildly to catch it. It bounces from her fingers once, twice. She dives forward for it, slamming her waist into the balcony and stretching over it, before finally snatching the bauble on its way down to the gardens below. Her

balance teeters on the precipice, then she tips forward. I catch her by the boot before she can topple face-first over the edge of the railing.

"Whoa—I gotcha!" I pull her back to her feet.

"Scorpia!" Adora places a hand on her chest to calm herself. "You scared the shit outta me."

"Sorry! Sorry! I was just… I didn't know how to…" I try to cobble together words but can't find any appropriate for the moment. "I just had a question for you. Didn't mean to startle ya."

She sits back on the railing behind her and glances at her hand still clenched in a fist around whatever she'd nearly dropped. A quiet relieved breath. "It's okay. I wasn't paying attention. Caught up in my thoughts, I guess."

"A quiet moment to yourself, eh?"

"Yeah, something like that," she says distractedly. She forcibly pulls her focus to me. "Did you need something?"

"I was just looking for Perfuma."

Adora turns and leans her elbows back against the rail. "She and Catra are still at it." There's an undertone to her voice that I can't quite place. Maybe she's still recovering from nearly falling.

I join her at the railing. A wind rustles through the trees below, the sound reminiscent of its moniker, the Whispering Woods. I watch a flock of birds pass by on their way to a distant waterfall. "The whole crickets thing?"

"No, those are bugs." Adora scrunches up her eyes as she tries to find the right word. "I think it's supposed to be catwalks."

"Well, that doesn't seem right. Why would Catra need help with those?"

“No idea. Perfuma just said they needed straightening and it would take a lot of focus so maybe I should go on a walk or something.” She shrugs and looks down where she holds her clasped hand with the other. An extra layer of protection for whatever lays within. “I guess she has a lot of them because they’re still working on it. They’ve been at it for hours.”

I push off the rail and turn to look back at the castle where I was sure Perfuma and Catra were somewhere. I know how long meditation could take, but it doesn’t make it any easier to wait. “Well shoot. Perfuma and I were gonna get to the end of Mer-Mysteries: The Tide Also Rises today. I wanna know what happens to Sebastian…”

Adora lets out a breathy laugh, still distracted. “Mermista got you into those books, too?”

“Eh, not really. I’m more of a romance reader myself.” I touch a pincer to my chest and shrug. “But Perfuma likes them and I like them a lot more when we read together.”

“I got that one copy sitting on my shelf in my room. I haven’t had the chance to sit down and read it.”

I can’t help but chuckle. “Well, you should give it a try whenever you get a chance. I think you'll like something in there."

“I’ll check it out sometime.” She nods absently, her tone distinctly noncommittal. She unclenches her hand and turns a small golden object between her fingers. “How are you and Perfuma, by the way? I haven’t really gotten to see much of you two.”

“Oh, Perfuma is just great. She’s so wonderful and understanding and I just—” I sigh and lean onto the railing, resting my cheek against my pincer. Just thinking about her sends a flutter through my chest that I don’t think I’ll ever get used to. “I don’t know what I did to deserve her.” I blush when I realize what I’ve just said and I’m not sure if it’s okay to say these things.

I've never really had anyone to say these things about before. Maybe I should apologize, but the words die in my throat.

Adora is smiling at me. Her eyes drift out across Etheria toward the glowing horizon. A level of thoughtfulness enters her voice as she says, "You deserve love too, Scorpia. I'm glad you and Perfuma are happy."

"So happy!" I toss my arms into the air to help illustrate exactly the breadth of that happiness. "Like, growing up, I didn't know that someone could be this happy, you know?"

She nods slowly, the smile vanishing from her lips, still turning over the golden trinket in her fingers.

"Wasn't easy finding reasons to be happy in the Horde, was it?" I settle my forearms back against the rail and look out across the Whispering Woods. The same woods I journeyed through with Emily to come here, to Bright Moon. How terrified I was. How determined. So much has changed since then. "I think leaving the Horde was the hardest thing I ever did."

Adora chuffs a harsh laugh. "Tell me about it."

I glance at her sideways, noting an imperceptible weight that seems to drag her shoulders downward. "You know, it took a long time for me to wake up happy again."

"Somehow, I don't believe that." She smirks slightly, throwing me a quick glance before focusing back on the bauble. "You always seemed so… chipper. Even during the worst of the invasion."

"Yeah, I know." I let out a sigh and lean a little harder on my forearms. On the garden tiers below us, a group of children play tag between the towers of the topiary. Not a care in the world to disturb their rambunctiousness. "I always try to be happy outside even when I don't feel it inside. Every morning, I'd wake up and breathe in a new day and push down doubts and insecurities. It can be… exhausting honestly."

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"What? Did I say something weird? Jeez, I'm sorry. I do that sometimes."

"No… just…" She shakes her head slowly and drops her eyes to hands again. "Waking up happy. I've never really tried to do that before. There were a lot of mornings when I could have used that. I wonder…" Her words falter and she clutches the curio tightly in a fist before letting out a long breath. She looks like a woman who has arisen from a fight, scarred but victorious. Burdened beneath an unshakable weariness.

She needs some cheering up.

"I think you did great! It might've been hard but you got us up and moving. Shoot, sometimes we were just trying to keep up." I chuckle and nudge her with an elbow. "You made it easier to wake up happy. At least for me. We were afraid that you'd give up sometimes—you took on so much. More than we should've let you, but we always trusted in you. And good thing we did, huh?" The memories burn like dry ice, but I try not to shy away from them. Perfuma always said there is strength in adversity, and I want to keep hold of that strength. "I'm glad it's over. Things are quieter again."

Some of the tension has eased from Adora's expression and she smiles wanly at me. "I like the quiet," she says.

"Me too." I return the smile. Still got it.

We let ourselves exist in the quiet for a moment. It's not a traditional quiet—it's actually quite noisy. The laughter of the children playing below, the roaring of the waterfalls across the way, the wind through the woods. The evening was anything but quiet, but it harmonized with the quiet within. Inner peace. That's what Perfuma called it anyway.

"Scorpia." Adora looks down and clenches her fist around the bauble, whites of her knuckles bearing, before relaxing again. "Are we… friends?"

"What?" I nearly fall over, the question taking me completely off guard. "What kind of question is that? Of course we are!"

Adora wears a muted smile. "I know. You and Perfuma are friends with everybody. But… not like that. Not in that way. I don't mean like *sure* we hang out together and aren't actively trying to kill each other anymore." She laughs a little awkwardly. "I suppose all of Etheria kind of counts by those standards." A pause as she turns over the trainket. "No, I mean it like… like we share something."

"Well, we shared lots of things!" I tap my pincer on the rail as I list them off. "We were both in the Horde. We were both Force Captains. Remember sitting in the briefing room? Oh man, I gave you so much crap about your hair." I laugh at the memory and resist the urge to bop her hair poof right now.

Adora shifts her weight, locking her boot behind an ankle again and clutching her elbows with her hands. She bites her lip, as though debating saying something.

"Oh shoot, that was the Portal thing, wasn't it?" A hot flush washes over my cheeks. "That was so confusing, wasn't it? It's hard to remember."

"Nevermind." She shakes her head and pushes off from the rail. "It's not important. I was just—"

"Catra."

She freezes mid-step before she can walk away. Her hands are two taut fists at her sides. She turns halfway back, looking up at me with a mixture of confusion and a surprising anger.

I guess I probably look the same right now. A weight lands firmly in my chest. I already regret using her name. I never… I

didn't want to… There's so much to say and I never wanted to say it. I calm myself. I close my eyes and take in a deep breath. I hear Perfuma. Her words. *Take in the good air, and push out the bad. Purify your thoughts, your mind, and your soul.*

I meet Adora's eyes again. She hasn't moved, still standing uncomfortably that half-pace away. It bleeds into the air around us.

I need to fix this.

The words don't come easily and I fidget. Alternately setting my pincers on my hips, before dropping them, before scratching behind my neck. This is somehow harder than it was with Catra. More complicated. A conversation I never really thought I would have, and maybe part of me wanted to avoid. But I can't ignore it now—I won't. "I… We both… Catra's hard, isn't she? And she…" I look at Adora again and the words stop.

Pain. It's painted across her expression. I've seen her face down an army of soldiers from both sides. I even recall from the haze of the chip her intransigent determination while fighting her. She never looked scared, she never looked… lost. But now? She was ready to shatter like a dropped porcelain dish.

I take in a deep breath. "She hurt both of us. And we both had to deal with that."

There's a tear, a single one in the corner of her eye. A long breath escapes her, seeming to take the strength out of her. She backs into her rail, hugging her arms around herself and looks up at the sky. The first traces of stars are just beginning to pierce through the intensity of the sunset. I want to scoop her up and swaddle her until she forgot about it all. A good hug could fix anything. But not right now. Personal space, Scorpia. Personal space. Now was the time for words.

"Adora… you…" I struggle to sort through the mess of feelings in my chest, lingering thoughts from days long past. "You left,

right? And then Shadow Weaver assigned me with Catra and then Entrapta and I thought… I thought a lot of things about Catra in the Super Pal Trio. And I thought I could do better than you. I thought maybe that Catra just needed a special kind of attention —that maybe we could fix things. I thought maybe you gave up on her too easy and I could change her."

"Scorpia…" Her words are distant and cold as though they came right out of the Kingdom of Snows.

"No, listen…" I start pacing, my nerves channeling into my legs. I know this isn't coming out exactly right, but I have to say it. "I was wrong. You… you did the right thing. With Catra. She… I didn't realize it soon enough, or just maybe I ignored it for too long. Not until things were so bad and I had to lie about it to everyone and… and myself. I had to lie to make myself happy."

Adora is an immobile statue that I only notice in my periphery while I pace. It's probably better this way. I think if I look at her right now, if I see whatever was in her expression, I'll lose all courage to continue saying what needs to be said.

"Maybe it's just how we were taught in the Horde, but I thought that was the way things were and if I just kept going it'd make everything okay with Catra. But it didn't. It only got worse, and I let it get worse until I couldn't let it anymore. I had to leave. But I didn't just need to walk away from the Horde, or Catra, or go face the princesses."

My pacing stops and I face Adora again. She's listening, though her eyes are still fixed on the sky. Sensing my stillness, she drops her gaze to mine, an unwavering empathy within it. Maybe if she looked at me any other way, I wouldn't have continued.

"Honestly? Secretly? I was scared of you," I tell her. "Because you were right and I didn't know if I could tell you. And I didn't… I've been a coward because I couldn't ever tell you that you did the right thing. Not just for you, but also for her. And I'm really, really sorry it took me this long to say it Adora."

She wears astonishment so strangely. The tear had fallen, but none replace it. She's rigid, frozen where she stands with the beauty of Bright Moon as her backdrop. I must've said it wrong. I shouldn't have said it. It felt like the right thing. Slowly, she unwinds her arms from around herself, the taught tension easing from her as she leans back on her elbows against the rail.

She can barely meet my eyes as she softly says, "No one… No one's ever told me that before."

"Well gosh darnit, they *should've* !" I point at her emphatically and she jumps slightly in surprise. I wonder if now is a good time for a hug? Maybe not. She still looks fragile. I drop my pincer and join her back at the railing. "Are you okay? I said a lot."

"No, it's okay. I'm…" Adora pauses and takes a deep breath. Her expression relaxes into a more neutral one, a weary one. I recognize it, having seen it across the rebellion's camps during the worst of the invasion, but there was a calm to it. She opens her hand to reveal the golden trinket once more. "Thanks Scorpia. That means a lot to me. That's actually kind of what I was up here thinking about."

"Do you wanna talk about it?" I ask quietly.

She seems to consider carefully, turning over the gold in her fingers as though turning over her thoughts. "Maybe…"

"Are you and Catra okay?"

"Yeah!" she says almost too quickly. "I mean, I think so. Maybe… I don't know. I'm not sure really what that means, I guess." She chuckles awkwardly, the mirth draining from her like a deflating balloon. "Everything is so different and we're all still adjusting. Catra is…"

Adora's hands freeze around the bauble and I get my first good look at it. A small golden wing. The symbol of Bright Moon. It matches the one she wears on her belt, but when I glance down,

I see she's still wearing hers. I wonder why she has a second one then.

"All those things that happened back then," she says, her eyes transfixed on the wing. "Sometimes I wish I could go back to where this all started. Back before… before everything. There's so much I wish I could change. Do differently. But I know I can't and everything that happened led to this. And things are good now so that's okay. So can we… Is it possible to just move on? Is that an option?"

I blink, processing what Adora just said. "Ooh dang that's… uh… that's a tough one." I tap my pincer on my chin. "I get what you're saying though. It took a lot to get here, but I mean, I've never been happier. And who's to say anything would change for the better."

She doesn't seem to hear me. She lightly raps the tips of the metal wing against her knuckles, frowning down at them. "I think we can move on. I mean, I did. Or at least, I want to."

I blow out a long breath and lean back on my elbows. "Yeesh. It's a lot, isn't it?"

She smiles wanly. "That's one way of putting it."

"Gosh, Adora. I don't know. I think about it sometimes. How can I just be here? How can any of this be okay? We fought and fought. All those things we were taught in the Horde—about our enemies and duties and purpose—none of that really matters anymore." I glance sideways at her, still studying the medallion. "But it's like, without the Horde, do I really have a purpose anymore and sometimes I wonder if I ever had one. I know we were lied to a lot, but some of it had to be true, right?"

"I…" Adora frowns and tilts her head. "I think so. Most of it was lies, but… I like to think that our friendships were real. That it was the one thing they couldn't control about us." She turns to me, a small twist of a hopeful smile.

"That was the hardest part, I think. Figuring all that out…" I let out a long sigh and slump against the railing. "I didn't really know what to think or how to act. It was weird, wasn't it?"

"Huh?" She meets my eyes, brow furrowing.

"When you came to Bright Moon. It was just… weird right?" I turn, resting back against the rail, and sweep my arm to indicate the castle rising against the ridgeline. The waterfalls glowed in the setting sunlight, casting rainbows across the zeniths of the towers. "No drills, no wake up calls, and people… smiled at you. I mean c'mon—you felt it, too."

"Hah, yeah." She shrugs noncommittally. "I guess."

"And we're just… we just have to be different now, you know? We had to learn how to be this way." I nod at some of the passing guards, the citizens of Bright Moon so at ease in their home. "They didn't. They kept being the people they always were. Wonderful and kind and loving people. So we had to just… you know… roll with it. Because what can we do? We can't *not* ." I pause and frown. "I guess we could, but that'd be super rude." I shake the thought from my head and turn back to Adora. "No, we just kinda need to let things be good and okay. And everything else seems to sort itself out."

She nods slowly, considering, turning the medallion over as though turning her thoughts over.

I set a pincer gently on her shoulder. "I had to learn how to trust that. You did too. And now, I think it's Catra's turn."

"But what if…" The words die in her throat and she scowls down at her hand. She looks back up at me with a conflict of emotions similar to the face I saw before. Her certainty hangs on a knife edge. She's not the Adora I recognize. In the twilight of Bright Moon, she doesn't look like a soldier or a fighter. She doesn't even look like the woman who can summon She-Ra. She looks like a person facing the most terrifying uncertainty. It always feels so

easy to forget she's a person with all the things she's faced down and done for us. And a person needs a hand. "Scorpia."

I'm a little taken aback by her directness, but I say, "Yeah?"

"Do you…" Another brief falter before she says, "Do you think she can do it?"

"Oh, of course!" I brush her concern away with a wave of my pincer. "She's Catra. She's gotten through more than any of us."

"I guess…" Adora holds up the wing, studying them against the pastel sky. "Angella gave me my first pair of these when I got here. She thought it'd be a good way to show everyone what side I was on so they'd stop trying to kill me."

"Okay, what's *with* that?" I say exasperatedly. "I showed up and I had to run for my *life* before they stopped throwing things. Even *you* did it!"

Adora smirks. "To be fair, you showed up in the middle of a war meeting."

"Well… I didn't want to interrupt."

"They don't like Horde soldiers just showing up, I guess. Bow did mention the pitchforks and torches to me at least—not that I listened to him." She nudges me with an elbow. "I'm just glad I didn't have to face Frosta down."

I chuckle at the memory. "She's only *slightly* less terrifying than Glimmer."

Adora's smile broadens, and I suspect she's about the laugh, but then it fades when she looks at the medallion again. "I'm just worried…" She pinches the wing between her thumb and forefinger, sunlight glinting off the refulgent metal. "We were different, you know? We walked away. We came here because we chose to. But Catra never did. That choice was taken from her. I know I can push her sometimes and I don't want to, but I can't

always tell what she's thinking so I'm…" Another thought dies in birdsong around us. "I thought maybe giving her a set of the wings might help."

I grab her by the shoulders and shake her. "That's a great idea!"

My enthusiasm catches her off-guard, some of her hair dislodging from its ponytail as I jostle her. I collect myself and let her go. She only stands there, slightly stunned.

"I mean… I just think that she might…" I clear my throat, trying to organize my thoughts. "Perfuma has this thing about grounding, right? Roots or something. Those things that keep plants upright. I'm not as good with her metaphors." I make a strange digging motion with my pincers, trying to illustrate my point. Adora's expression only deepens in confusion so I stop. "But anyway, the idea is that you have to find something to grab onto and *maybe* if she has something like that it might help her if she gets a little lost or whatever." I beam and bump her on the shoulder with a pincer. "Plus it matches yours so it's even better!"

The confusion eases from her expression and she looks down at the medallion in her hand. The smile that graces her lips now is earnest and heartfelt. She looks back at me and I feel the warmth of her affection for Catra. It's more than I've ever seen her smile since the Heart. That genuine glowing grin as she rubs her thumb over the golden wings. Things are settling, and the tension and fear around us lessens.

"Thanks, Scorpia," Adora says. "That really helped."

"Any time!" I smile brightly at her. "Perfuma says I'm getting pretty good at this advice thing. I figure it's the least I can do after everything you've done for us."

Adora's smile turns a little rueful. "Glad to know you don't hate me anymore."

"Oh, c'mon. I never hated you!" I whap her bracingly on the back and she staggers forward a step. "Hate is such a strong

word. Intense dislike maybe. You were pretty annoying in the Northern Reach though."

"So I've heard." She laughs wanly. She looks down at the wing in her hand and clutches them tightly in her fist. "I hope you're right about these."

"Oh, I'm definitely right." I place my pincers on my hips. "Our Wildcat's gonna love 'em."

Adora cocks her head at me in confusion. "Wildcat? What—" Her eyes drift to something behind me and she freezes mid-sentence, her face draining of color. She hastily locks her closed hand behind her back.

I turn to see Catra walking toward us, Melog at her heels. The normally adorable face looks as forlorn as Catra's. I don't understand their bond, but they're going through a lot together. Perfuma trails behind her, wearing that gentle, warm grin that brings the daylight like the sun cresting over the sea. She'd never know how beautiful those crinkles look in the corners of her eyes, or the delicate aura of happiness that surrounded her like the flowers that grew everywhere around her. But I felt it. And I hope I can tell her about it someday.

"Hey, Adora," Catra says as she approaches us. Her voice is strained but she carries a wan smile. Straightening her catwalks must sure be exhausting.

"Catra." Adora's smile blossoms like one of Perfuma's flowers, the moment of slight panic already in the past. "You doing okay?"

Catra heaves a slow sigh. Her hand absentmindedly brushes along Melog's head where they sit next to her. "Yeah… Just… a lot."

Perfuma holds her hands clasped in front of her. "Unlocking chakras can be a taxing experience. I suggest you take it easy tonight and drink lots of water."

There's a tightness to Catra's eyes as she smiles at her. "Thanks, Perfuma."

"Of course! We'll pick it up again in a few days."

Adora holds out her arms, low and in front of her waist. A reserved gesture—an invitation that could be accepted or denied. Catra doesn't even hesitate, but intertwines her arms through Adora's and lets her pull them closer. She leans in and touches their foreheads gently together. Melog wraps themselves around their legs, tail curling so as to encompass them both. It's only moments before a creaky purr starts low in Catra's chest. Whatever discomfort Catra had before was already forgotten.

Perfuma sidles up closer to me; the delicate bouquet of her flowers is rose and tulips today. Aromas I never knew were possible back in my former life. But now they are, and I get to experience them every day. She tugs gently on my pincer pulling me a little further away. I follow a little reluctantly, but Catra and Adora are almost on a completely different plane of existence. I doubt they are aware of anything else around them.

"You have a good time with Adora?" Perfuma asks quietly, as we walk away.

"Oh, yeah." I put my arm around her shoulders. "I was looking for you. I wanted to… to…" I tap the tip of my pincer on my chin. "You know, I don't really know anymore."

She goes up on her tiptoes to peck a kiss gently on my cheek. "If it's important, it will find its way back to you."

"How's she doing?"

"There is a lot of spiritual disharmony in her. She's been open to my guidance, but there are quite a few boundaries she still needs to cross." She pauses, trouble encroaching on her tranquility. "I'm worried about her."

"Well, she's Catra, and she's got Adora. If they can save Etheria, I think they can figure out some bad feelings." I spare a glance over my shoulder, hearing the soft murmur of conversation from the two of them. Is Adora going to give it to her now?

"I hope so." Perfuma's arm tightens around mine. "They have a long way, but they're walking the path of love together."

I pull her behind a topiary. I can't help it. Curiosity killed the Catra but an Adora brought her back. Perfuma tugs again on my pincer but I resist. I peer around the edge of the shrub, past the spatulate leaves. Catra is holding tight to Adora now, her face tucked into her red jacket. Adora embraces her, the medallion glinting in the setting sunlight where she held it behind Catra's back.

"Scorpia, we shouldn't—"

"Shh! I wanna see how it goes."

Reluctantly, Adora lets Catra go. Catra's tail flicks in slight agitation behind her as Adora holds up the golden wings of Bright Moon between them. That little broach can mean so much. The wings that she carried in place of the brand of the Evil Horde. Her head is downturned, focused on the medallion and not Catra's face. Melog glances between the two of them, tilting their head in curiosity. I can't hear what Adora says, but I can see the sincerity and determination in her expression. The unbridled hope.

An unbearably long pause follows in its wake, dissonant with the pleasant birdsong of a Bright Moon evening and the distant thundering of the waterfalls. A cold wave of dread starts at the base of my neck but it's usurped by a rush of joy as Catra reaches up with both of her hands and gently takes the wings from Adora.

Another quiet something shared between the two of them. A slight nod from Catra, eliciting a dumbfounded, numb nod from Adora in response. The melodic chuckle of Catra carries over to

us. She wraps her arms around Adora's neck and pulls her into an inevitable kiss.

I turn to Perfuma. "Okay, now we can go."

She smiles at me. "What'd you do?"

"Oh, nothing really." I lead Perfuma away from the gardens and the beauty of the balcony of Bright Moon. "We all like to help in our own ways."

End Notes

We would just like to give a quick thanks to everyone that's been following the story thus far and leaving so many thoughtful comments. We can't wait for you all to dig into Adora's story next! Girl has gone through a lot and we wanted to put her through some more...

~~~Stay tuned~~~

Please drop by the Archive and comment to let the creator know if you enjoyed their work!
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